HAMASPIK LEOVDEI HASHEM

A Ramp, Not Steps: How to Attain Perishut

Given Monday 2 November 2026 · HaMaspik LeOvdei HaShem 10.3

Sefer: HaMaspik L'Ovdei Hashem (Rabbeinu Avraham ben HaRambam); Rabbeinu Avraham's commentary on the Torah for the weekly parashah

Chapter: Perek Yud (10) — **Perishut**, abstinence (Part 3: how to attain it)

Topic: Rabbeinu Avraham on **Parashat Chayei Sarah** — why Yitzchak was "coming back" from **באר לחי ראי**, and why he moved there only **after Avraham's death**; the **intellectual path** to perishut (sensual pleasure, clothes, homes and power are not who we are; Shlomo's verdict **הכל הבל**); the real obstacle — **habit**; the **two stages** (training for beginners, second nature for the prophets); **Yom Kippur**, the Rechavim and the Chovot HaLevavot as proofs; and the first **practical guidance**: assess yourself honestly, then change **slowly — a ramp, not steps**.

Schedule note: Throughout the winter the HaMaspik shiur is **Monday, 6:00–7:00pm**, b'ezrat Hashem. **Next week** the Rabbi will **skip ahead within Chapter 10** to Rabbeinu Avraham's long discussion of **Yitzchak's blessings** — it falls exactly on **Parashat Toldot** — and will take the whole shiur. There will be no separate parashah feature next week. We return to the section on **fasting** the week after.

The Weekly Feature — Rabbeinu Avraham on the Parashah

Each week we look at something small from **Rabbeinu Avraham's commentary on the Torah**, which survives on **Bereishit and Shemot**. Last week (Vayera) we saw three or four ideas — Yitzchak and Yishmael, the difference between the phrases of timing, and more. This week, **Parashat Chayei Sarah**, two ideas — *"which is really one idea"* — about the same place: **באר לחי ראי**.

Part One — Rabbeinu Avraham on Parashat Chayei Sarah

The setting

Avraham sends his servant — called **עבד** throughout, identified as **Eliezer** — to find a wife for Yitzchak. Eliezer finds **Rivka**, negotiates with her father and brother, **Betuel and Lavan**, and brings her home. As they travel back, Yitzchak has gone out **to meditate in the field** — *Chazal* tell us, to pray **Mincha** — and on his way back he meets Rivka. She is in awe of him, and falls from the camel.

ויצחק בא מבוא באר לחי ראי, והוא יושב בארץ הנגב. (Bereishit 24:62)

Yitzchak was **living with his father in the Negev**, somewhere in the south — but he was **coming back from Be'er Lachai Roi**.

Rabbeinu Avraham's two questions:

1. **Why does the verse stress that he was *coming back*?**

2. **What is Be'er Lachai Roi — and what was he doing there?**

1. Why "coming back" from Be'er Lachai Roi?

אין ספק כי המרחק רב בין באר לחי ראי ובין המקום שאברהם ויצחק היו שוכנים בו.

There was **quite a distance** between Be'er Lachai Roi and where Avraham and Yitzchak lived. So why go there?

אך יצחק רגיל להיפרד ממקום מושבו וללכת אל המדבר, אל הבאר הנזכרת, בדבקותו בעבודתו וחפצו לבקש התבודדות כדרך החסידים והנביאים, כמו שביארנו בספר המספיק בפרק ההתבודדות.

Yitzchak **regularly** left home and went out into the wilderness, to that well, **because of his attachment to his avodah and his wish for solitude** — the way of the righteous and the prophets. Rabbeinu Avraham points to the **chapter on hitbodedut** in HaMaspik itself — **Chapter 12**. (*We are in Chapter 10 now; there are 13 chapters. Chapter 12 is about the importance of quiet time alone — thinking, contemplating, meditating.*)

ויתעכב שם זמן קצר, ושוב היה חוזר למקום מושבו.

He would stay a short while, and then return home.

Why the emphasis on returning?

סיפר לנו הכתוב כי הפגישה הנזכרת היתה בזמן חזרת יצחק מהבאר, לא בזמן יציאתו. ועילת דבר זה, כפי הנראה לי — כדי להודיע לבני התורה שיצחק עליו השלום יצא לעבודתו, וחזר, משהגיעה רבקה עם אליעזר. ואילו היה פוגע בהם בהליכתו, לא היה חוזר מעבודתו; אלא היתה פגישתו עמהם אחר שגמר עבודתו.

The meeting happened on Yitzchak's way **back**, not on his way **out** — *"so that students of Torah should know"*: had he met them **on his way to his avodah**, he **would not have turned back** — **not even to meet his wife for the very first time**. He met them only because he had already finished.

	On the way out	**On the way back**
What Yitzchak was doing	Going to pray, meditate, be *mitboded*	Had finished his avodah
Would he have stopped for Rivka?	**No** — he would not interrupt his avodah	**Yes** — and he did
What it teaches	How deeply **דבוק** he was in his avodah	

The Rabbi: this is the **awe** that Yitzchak clearly carried — an awe Rivka saw, and fell from the camel because of it. He was so attached to his avodah that he only met her because he was already on his way home.

2. Why did Yitzchak move to Be'er Lachai Roi — and why only after Avraham died?

The last verse in the parashah:

ויהי אחרי מות אברהם, ויברך אלהים את יצחק בנו, וישב יצחק עם באר לחי ראי. (25:11)

Until now he **visited** Be'er Lachai Roi; **after Avraham's death he went to live there.**

ישיבתו של יצחק אצל הבאר — בשביל שהבחיר עליו השלום מצא שם עבודת השם; ובחיי אברהם לא היה יכול להיפרד ממנו, אלא היה חוזר ושב מאצל אביו אל הבאר ומן הבאר אצל אביו.

- **Why there?** Because Yitzchak found that **this was where he truly connected to Hakadosh Baruch Hu** — where his time alone developed his avodat Hashem.
- **Why only now?** Because while Avraham was alive, **he could not leave his father**. However much spiritual benefit he gained from his solitude, *"while my father is alive, I can't leave him."* So he travelled back and forth — though it took a great deal of his time — because **being with his father mattered**.

וכשנסתלק אברהם עליו השלום לעולם האמת, נסע יצחק וקבע מושבו אצל הבאר שבחר בה, בשביל סגולה שהיה מוצא שם.

Once Avraham passed away, Yitzchak **moved there** and settled by the well he had chosen, **because of the special quality he found there**.

The idea to take away

Before Rabbeinu Avraham, we read **Be'er Lachai Roi** as a random place name. It isn't. It is **the place where Yitzchak developed himself spiritually** — the place he would have lived all along — and he waited **only out of kibbud av**.

- **The significance of a place of solitude** for one's avodah.
- **The importance of honouring and looking after one's parents** — even above one's own spiritual preference.

Part Two — A Change of Plan for Next Week

"I don't like to skip." But Rabbeinu Avraham has **a beautiful commentary on Parashat Toldot** inside this very chapter on perishut — all about **the blessings of Yitzchak, Esav and Yaakov**. Learning in order, we would reach it in three weeks — after Toldot has passed.

So: tonight we continue where we left off. **Next week** we skip ahead within Chapter 10 to the section on the blessings, with **no separate parashah feature** — *"it'll be really appropriate, and it's a beautiful explanation of the whole concept of the blessings; it will take the whole shiur, b'ezrat Hashem."* Then we come back to the section on **fasting**.

Part Three — Recap: Where We Are in Chapter 10

- **The human being is חומר (matter) and צורה (form/intellect)**; a person's identity needs both.
- **Perishut is a vital trait.** The prophets and the righteous chose **simple work** — farmers, shepherds — that freed them to focus on Hakadosh Baruch Hu; and the Torah shows its importance (consecrating the captured Canaanite cities, and more).
- **The definition — the vital point:** perishut is **not** living simply while constantly thinking about what you are giving up. **True perishut sprouts from the heart.** A true *parush* abstains and **doesn't need to think about** what he is missing.
- So **a wealthy person can be a *parush*** — it doesn't affect him; and **a poor person who lives very simply may not be** — he is thinking about it all the time. *A person is where his heart is, where his mind is.*

Now: how do we attain it? Rabbeinu Avraham works in two stages — **first intellectually**, then **practical advice**.

Part Four — The Intellectual Path to Perishut

The battle is in the mind

ובאשר לדרך השגתה של הפרישות האמיתית, כלומר זו שבלב — הרי מאבק לעמוד כנגד הדחף הטבעי, שכן אהבת העולם נטועה בלב האדם.

Attaining real perishut — the kind in the heart — is **a battle against our natural drive**, because **love of this world is planted in the human heart**. It is part of our *chomer*.

ואמר שלמה המלך: גם את העולם נתן בלבם. (Kohelet 3:11) *(More on this in Chapter 11.)*

ברם עיקר המאבק — שיחליט האדם בדעתו החלטה נקייה מנגיעה אישית ומנטיית סמיות, כי תענוגות העולם הזה אינם תכלית היותו אדם.

The main battle is **an intellectual decision** — clear, free of self-interest and bias — that **the pleasures of this world are not the purpose of being human**. They don't define who I am; they are auxiliary to my real identity.

The Rabbi: before any practical step — fasting, simple clothing and so on — **there is no point in any of it if you haven't first made the right intellectual choice.**

(1) Sensual pleasure — shared with animals

שאפילו התענוגות היותר גדולים בנוגע לחושים, שמלכי הארץ משתמשים בכוח שליטתם — הם אכילה, שתייה ומשגל — הרי הם שותפים בהם עם הבהמות: כלב, חמור, חזיר ושאר בעלי חיים.

Even the **greatest sensual pleasures**, the kind kings can command with all their power — **the best food, drink and relations** — **we share with the animal kingdom**.

So that can't be your identity. Perhaps you enjoy more sensual pleasure than other people. *"Okay, lovely — but it hasn't changed who you are."* The lion, king of the animals, may enjoy more than other animals — *maybe, maybe not* — but you are still sharing a trait with animals. **Intellectually, this cannot be the purpose.**

*We learned this in the **Rambam's Introduction to the Mishnah**, where the Rambam makes the same argument — and Rabbeinu Avraham takes it directly from his father.*

(2) The more physical, the more embarrassed

ועוד צריך להתבונן, כי תענוגות העולם הזה, ככל שהם גסים ומגושמים ורחוקים מן האנושות — גם מגונים בדעת.

"A very interesting point." **The more sensual something is, the more embarrassed we are by it.** *"Have you ever thought about that?"*

ולכן יצניע האדם את עצמו בשעת המשגל, ולא בשעת אכילה... ויש שיצניעו בשעת אכילה ושתיית מים.

Act	How private we are about it
Marital relations	Almost everyone conceals it
Eating	Most don't mind eating in public — but more sensitive people prefer to eat privately
Drinking	Most don't mind — the even more sensitive won't even drink in front of others
Smelling	The least physical — *"I don't know anyone who's embarrassed to smell something in front of other people"*

(More on this in Chapter 13.) The conclusion: **it cannot be that this is the reason Hashem made us.** We share it with animals, and we are naturally embarrassed by it.

(3) Fine clothes — only appearance

ואשר לבגדים נאים — כיוון שמיוחדים הם לאדם על פני בעלי חיים שאין בהם דעה, יתפאר האדם בהם, כמו שנאמר: הדרת אדם לבושו.

Animals don't wear clothes; we do — so a person likes to think his clothes exalt him. *Chazal* say **"a person's clothes are his glory"** — they can tell you a lot about him.

ואף על פי כן, באמת תמצא כי נוי הבגדים אינו אלא דמיון... בו יוכל אדם להטעות זולתו לחשוב שיש בו גדולה.

But **beautiful clothing is only an image** — a way to *impress*, not quite deceive, others into thinking we have some greatness, power or wealth.

הלא רוב בני אדם מוציאים זמנם לריק בסידור המצנפת, ובשיעור עטיית הבגד, ובצחצוח הנעליים, וסוברים שמעשיהם מורים על נוי — ואינם יודעים שזו שפלות וגאווה ושיגעון.

Most people **waste their time** perfecting the hat, making sure the suit or dress is just right, **polishing their shoes** — and think this shows they are someone special. *"And that's all there is; there's nothing more to it."*

The proof: if a person were alone, where no one could see him — would he bother to put on his finest clothes? *"If you're alone, you take your clothes off. So that can't be who you are."*

(4) Mansions — for other people's eyes

ואותם המסתופפים בבתי פאר — אינם בוחרים בהם על פי רוב אלא כדי שיתגדלו בעיני הבריות, ולא כדי שימצאו שם מקום נאה.

Most people who live in **huge, luxurious houses** do so **to gain approval from others** — not because it is truly nicer.

שאם לא כן — הרי מראה גן, או כברת דשא, או שדה רענן, משובבים את הנפש מאוד יותר. והלא אם יכלאו אדם לחודש תמים בתוך ארמון המלך, שתקרתו זהב ורצפתו כסף — תצטער נפשו על פי רוב, וישתוקק אל מראה שדה עשב.

"He says something so true." **A patch of green grass refreshes the soul far more.** Lock a person for **a whole month** inside the king's palace — **gold ceiling, silver floor** — and he will be longing to get out and

see **some grass, some green**.

A balance — "most of the time": the **Gemara in Berachot** says **אשה נאה, דירה נאה וכלים נאים מרחיבים דעתו של אדם** — a pleasant home **broadens a person's mind**, and the Rambam speaks of this too. *"It's true — it is nice to live in a clean, nice house."* If you have it, it can help you think clearly. **But most people who chase these things aren't doing it for that** — they want *the biggest, the most expensive*.

(5) Power and authority — the most subtle of all

וכן אהבת השררה והשלטון — אף שהיא דבר שבנפש, הרי היא אהבת דבר שאינו חלק מתכונת האדם ועצמותו, אלא אדרבה, דבר הטורד מן השלמות.

Power is **not physical** — the most subtle thing so far. But **it still isn't who you are** — and worse, **it distracts from perfection**.

כמו שאמר שלמה: שמוני נוטרה את הכרמים, כרמי שלי לא נטרתי. (Shir HaShirim 1:6)

- **It pulls you away from yourself.** *"I was made guardian of everyone else's vineyards — but my own vineyard I didn't keep."* You are so busy dealing with the people under you that you never deal with yourself.
- **It depends on others. If a person were alone, he would have no authority at all.** You need other people under you to have it — so clearly **it is not part of who you are**.

What people pursue	Why it can't be the purpose
Food, drink, relations	We share them with animals — and we are embarrassed by them
Fine clothes	Only an image to impress others — alone, you wouldn't bother
Mansions	Mostly for others' approval — a field of grass refreshes more
Power and authority	Distracts from yourself — and needs others to exist at all

The conclusion — and Shlomo HaMelech's experiment

הוי אומר: מי שמתעסק בכל אלו — בתענוגות החושים, ובדמיונות שבהם, ובשררה — הרי הוא מתעסק בדברים שמחוץ לעצמותו, ואינם שלמות. ועליהם נאמר: משמרים הבלי שוא, חסדם יעזובו. (Yonah 2:9)

Whoever focuses on these is developing **things outside himself, which are not perfection** — *"you're wasting your time."*

וידוע אתה כי שלמה המלך השיג מן החכמה והבינה מה שלא השיג איש זולתו; ועל פי עדותו התענג בכל מיני תענוגות וקנה רכוש... ורצה להבין מה התועלת בכל אלה כפי חכמתו ובינתו — ומצא שאין בהם חפץ.

Shlomo HaMelech **had everything** — and, with his unmatched wisdom, examined what it was all worth:

תרתי בלבי למשוך ביין את בשרי... הגדלתי מעשי, בניתי לי בתים... וכל אשר שאלו עיני לא אצלתי מהם... ופניתי אני בכל מעשי שעשו ידי ובעמל שעמלתי לעשות — והנה הכל הבל ורעות רוח, ואין יתרון תחת השמש. (Kohelet 2)

I tried wine; I built myself houses; whatever my eyes asked for, I didn't deny them — and then I looked at it all: **it is all vanity, and there is no lasting gain.** *Full stop.*

Part Five — The Real Obstacle: Habit

"Intellectually, I think this is clear. I don't think any of us should struggle with this." We **know** our pleasures, homes, clothes — even our power — are not who we are. **So what's the problem?**

אלא שההישג הזה על ידי ההגות השכלית — סותרים אותו הרגלי המעשים היומיומיים.

The daily rush of life — and our habits — make us forget these intellectual truths. Anyone with a brain knows what we've said is true. *"But if you tell me, now start living according to it — that's too hard. I know it's true, but I don't want to."*

Rabbeinu Avraham's examples: it's all about what you're used to

Example	The point
The man with a chariot — מי שרגיל לרכוב על סוסי מרכבות מתבייש ללכת בשוק כשהוא הולך רגלי	Used to riding, he is **embarrassed to walk** — he'd rather eat dry bread at home than be seen without his horse. *(Today: always driven by your driver, and embarrassed to go without.)*
The merchant — הסוחר... הולך ונושא סחורתו בשוק ואינו מתבייש	A peddler who always walks, carrying his goods, **isn't embarrassed at all**.
The married man and the single man	A married man finds it hard to be away from his wife **even one week**; one who is unmarried, or travels abroad for business, can manage far longer. As the Gemara says: **אינו דומה מי שיש לו פת בסלו למי שאין לו פת בסלו**.
Fasting several days — הצם הרבה ימים רצופים, יתענה ברעב ביום ראשון יותר מביום שני, וביום שני יותר מביום שלישי, עד שיעשה לו הצום טבע שני	**The first day is the hardest**; each day gets easier, until fasting becomes **second nature**.

The lesson: the more used to something we are, the harder it is to give up — **and the reverse is also true.**

Stage one — summary

Recognise the intellectual truth, by **contemplating the reality** that what most people seek — the best food, drink, women, clothes, homes and power — **is not intrinsic to a person's identity**: we share it with animals, and we are naturally embarrassed by it. **We know it; habit stops us living it.**

Part Six — The Two Stages: Training and Second Nature

והוא הדין בכל דברי העולם הזה ובמראיתן. ולכן שקדו החסידים והנביאים על התשת הרגלי העולם, נוסף על התמדת פרישת הלב.

So the righteous and the prophets worked to **break their worldly habits** — **in addition to** the perishut of the heart.

A question raised at the start of the chapter

The Rabbi: this whole chapter seems to contradict the **Rambam in the Eight Chapters** (*Shemonah Perakim*, which we learned a couple of years ago), where he says it is **wrong** to forsake the pleasures of this world — and here Rabbeinu Avraham seems to say the opposite. **We'll deal with that in depth, probably next time** — but this is the opening.

Stage 1 — the beginners: external training

לבשו צמר והסתפקו במאכלים גסים, וקשרו עצמם במעט שבתענית; וקצתם פרשו מנשים, ונעתקו ממגוריהם, והתגוררו במערות הרים וגבעות רחוקים מן הישוב.

To break the habit, some wore **simple wool**, ate **coarse food**, took on **some fasting**; some **separated from their wives** for a period (as Moshe Rabbeinu did), or **left home to live in caves**, far from settlement. *We have evidence there were Jews like this — Rabbeinu Bachya writes about it.*

וכל זה למי שהתחיל בהרגלים האלה, כמו תלמידי הנביאים בתחילת הכשרתם.

But note this line: *all of this is for **beginners*** — like the students of the prophets at the start of their training. **This is not the real thing.** The real thing is in the heart.

Stage 2 — second nature

ומי שהתבסס בחסידות, וכל שכן הנביאים, התחזקו בעבודה כזאת שנעשתה להם הפרישות טבע שני, ואין לבם הולך אחר מה שאיננו בגדר ההכרח שנצרך לחייו... כגון אם יאכל פת חרבה או מרקחת מתוקה, או ילבש משי או פשתן גס או צמר גס או כותנה; וכן הדבר בארמונות וסוכות.

Once fully developed — and certainly the prophets — **perishut becomes second nature**. **It makes no difference** to them:

- **Food:** *"Serve me the best meat or dry bread — I need food to live and to serve God. Whatever you give me, I don't care."*
- **Clothes:** *"The nicest silk or a simple thick garment — all I need is to be warm and covered."*
- **Home:** *"Give me the mansion or a tent in the desert — makes no difference to me."*

כי הפרישות שבלבם נשתרשה בהם, עד כדי כך ששוב אין להם צורך בהרחקה חיצונית כדי להישמר מן העבירות.

It is **ingrained in the heart** — they **no longer need external distancing**. *"This is what I told you last week, the week before: it's all about the heart, all about the intellect. Perishut is not about actions; it's about recognising."*

והמה החסידים אשר הזכירם הכתוב, כגון אליהו ואלישע ונביאים אחרים ההולכים בעקבותיהם... אבל מי שקטן מהם — מצטרך להתרחקות.

	The beginner	The developed (Eliyahu, Elisha, the prophets)
Knows the truth intellectually?	Yes	Yes
Lives it?	Habit gets in the way	It is **second nature**
Needs fasting, simple clothes, distance?	**Yes — as training**	**No**
Food / clothes / home	*"Meat is too much of a pleasure — I'd better fast"*	*"Makes no difference to me"*

The key point: the training is necessary for the beginner — **not because it's the real thing**, but to get out of the habit of enjoying these things. **You mustn't think it is the תכלית.**

Even great people had to train

- **Gechazi**, the student of **Elisha** — **הלא ראית איך שהביא העולם הזה את גיחזי לחשוב באותה שעה בכסף ובגדים** — fell and ran after money, *because it was not yet second nature to him; he was still training*.
- **Abba Chilkiya, Chanan HaNechba** and their colleagues were constantly working to engrain it.
- **David: זכור ה' לדוד את כל ענותו** — *remember all the training I went through.*
- **Daniel: לחם חמודות לא אכלתי, ובשר ויין לא בא אל פי, וסוך לא סכתי** — the times he restrained himself.
- **Yeshayahu: כאשר הלך עבדי ישעיהו ערום ויחף** — walked barefoot and unclothed.

The prophets all practised some abstinence at some point — but that was not the end goal. The end goal is that it becomes second nature.

A parallel from the chapter on bitachon

The Rabbi recalled the summer, when we learned **Chapter 8, Bitachon**: **three levels** of bitachon, the highest being full confidence that what you ask for will be given. Then Rabbeinu Avraham described **a fourth level** — *"I'm not even sure you can call this bitachon"* — where you have so absorbed the intellectual truth that **whatever happens is the best from Hakadosh Baruch Hu** that you no longer need to trust that anything will or won't happen.

"It's paradoxical — almost a kind of apathy. Not apathy in a negative sense, but: I don't care, because whatever Hakadosh Baruch Hu gives me is the best."

Perishut is the same: *I don't care whether you give me the best clothes or the worst, the best home or the worst, the best food or the worst — it's so ingrained in me that I don't get excited, or not excited, about these things.*

Of course this is an extremely high level. But it can be applied: **how excited do we get by physical, sensual things?** *Are we more excited when we learn and understand something — or when we get a new kind of meat to eat?* **These are questions we need to ask.**

Part Seven — The Proofs That Perishut Is Valued

ושמא תאמר: עניינם של פסוקים אלה אינם מעידים אלא היות הפרישות עיקרה לבקש רחמים לעת צרה?

Perhaps you'll say: the prophets fasted and went barefoot **not because perishut is valuable**, but only **to beseech Hashem in a time of trouble**.

על כך אשיבך: כי דווקא כאן מוציאים אנו ראיה צחה ועדות שלימה על עוצם שבח הפרישות ומעלתו היתרה, ורצון הבורא יתעלה בו.

That is exactly the proof. If abstinence is the means people use to come close to Hashem and seek His mercy — **that shows how valued it is**.

(1) Yom Kippur

ולכן חיברה התורה את העינוי עם הכפרה: ובחודש השביעי בעשור לחודש תענו את נפשותיכם... כי ביום הזה יכפר עליכם. (Vayikra 16:29–30)

The Torah ties atonement to affliction. On the day of atonement — *afflict yourselves* by not eating and drinking — *for on this day He will atone for you. "What better proof do you want?"* Abstinence is **a means of coming close to Hashem** — and the ultimate atonement depends on it. **In the heart** — but you may need to get there through physical training.

(2) The will of Yonadav ben Rechav

ממה שהובא בצוואת יונדב בן רכב לבניו — שידורו באהלים ולא ישתו יין — ושילם ה' שכרם על שקיימו מצות אביהם עליהם, כמו שמספר ירמיהו. (Yirmiyahu 35)

Yonadav ben Rechav — who helped King **Yehu** — commanded his descendants in his will **never to drink wine and always to live in tents**. They kept it, and **Hashem rewarded them**, as **Yirmiyahu** relates.

(3) The Chovot HaLevavot — even the false prophets knew it

וכמה ברור מה שכתב רבינו בחיי בחובות הלבבות, שהפרישות היא מנהג החסידים. *(Chovot HaLevavot, Sha'ar 6)*

How correct is Rabbeinu Bachya: perishut is **the practice of the righteous**. His proof from **Zechariah**:

ולא ילבשו אדרת שער למען כחש. (Zechariah 13:4)

Zechariah prophesies against the **false prophets**: a time will come when they **will no longer wear the hairy cloak to deceive**. **It was the practice of false prophets** to present themselves as holy — *"holier-than-thou"* — by dressing simply. **Which shows that living simply was recognised as a sign of spiritual level** — so perishut is an important trait.

End of the section — summary

The **intellectual way** to perishut is to **contemplate the falseness of physical things**. At first, a person needs **external acts** — fasting, simplicity — to **break the habit** of pursuing worldly pleasure. **But that is only the beginning.** The real level is that **it makes no difference to him or her** whether the food is good or not, because abstaining has become **second nature** — **the perishut of the chassidim and the prophets.**

Part Eight — Practical Guidance Begins

וכאן הנני פותח לך דרך המאבק הזה על ידי הדרכות הלכה למעשה, הנהגה כללית.

"Intellectually I've explained how to attain perishut. Now practically." General guidelines — *"there are lots of examples, and I'll try to tell you as much as I can."*

Principle 1 — habit cannot be changed in one go

עליך לדעת כי ההרגל, ביחוד אם נתאחד עם הטבע, אי אפשר לשנותו בבת אחת — אלא אם קרוב העניין למעשה ניסים; ואל תנסה.

Habit — especially habit joined to our nature — cannot be changed all at once, unless by something close to a miracle — *and don't rely on miracles*. *"This is the most simple thing — but it's worth repeating. This is the beauty of Rabbeinu Avraham: he tells us the most basic things, in a beautiful way."* Not from one day to the next, not one month to the next, not even one year to the next — **it is the work of a lifetime, and must be done extremely slowly.**

Principle 2 — first, an honest assessment

ולכן חייב אתה קודם כל לבדוק באיזו מידה שוגה לבך באהבת העולם הזה, ולבחון את הרגליך הקודמים שתמכו בעניין הזה.

"Oh, this is so beautiful." **Before you take on anything practical, you need to do something intellectual:**

- **(a)** How strongly is **my heart attached** to the pleasures of this world?
- **(b)** How **habitual** have I been in them?

"That's not something you do in five minutes." It's something to think about over a period of time.

The Rabbi's scale: say **10** is complete love for these things and **0** is no interest at all. **If you're at 8 or 9 and you start fasting — you'll go crazy.** Rabbeinu Avraham will say later that you will be **emotionally damaged**. So first, assess where you stand.

ואז אם נתעוררת שתוכל להתחיל בדבר זה, בדרך שנהגו הנביאים — תתחיל לשנות את הרגליך מעט מעט, מדרגה אחר מדרגה; ולא תחפוז, כי כל דבר בחפזון ישוב ריקם.

Then, if you feel ready — **change your habits little by little**. **Don't rush**: whatever is done in haste comes back empty-handed — *it falls back in your face*.

A ramp, not steps — ולא תעלה במעלות

ולא תעלה במעלות על מזבחי. (Shemot 20:23, end of Parashat Yitro)

The Rabbi cited this famous verse — and believes the **Vilna Gaon** explains it this way. You may not build **steps** up to the altar; it must be a **ramp**. **Steps mean jumping from level to level.** *"You don't jump in avodat Hashem. You go very gradually — 1.1, 1.2, 1.3 — slowly but surely, up the ramp."*

The worked example: five dishes

והנה לך דוגמה: אם היית מן החובבים את עניין האכילה, ורגיל אתה ללפת את הפת בכמה מאכלי תאווה בסעודה אחת, כדרכם של המפונקים, ואז גמרת אומר לעבור אל דרך החסידים... שמסתפקים בפת חרבה וכיוצא בזה —

You've done your self-assessment and realise: **"I like my food."** At every meal you have your main dish with all kinds of sides — *not a one-off celebration, but generally* — and now you decide to live like the chassidim, on dry bread.

הרי הדרך שבה תגיע למטרתך — איננה על ידי שינוי פתאומי... כי דרך זו לא תצלח; וגם אם תצלח, תביא אחריה מבוכה חיצונית ופנימית.

A sudden change will not work. *And listen to this:* **even if it does work, it will bring external and internal confusion.** *(Later he says it damages you emotionally and spiritually.) "We all know people who go cold turkey — give something up from one day to the next. It doesn't work. And even if it does, it causes issues."*

והדרכה הנכונה היא: שאם היית רגיל לאכול בסעודה אחת כמה מיני מאכלים, תפחית מעט מספרם — למשל אם היו חמישה, תעמיד אותם על ארבעה, ותשהה ימים או חודשים או שנים, עד שתמצא שהסתגלת לזה...

Step	What you do	Until when
1. Number of dishes	Five → **four** → three → two → **one**	Each stage until you no longer miss the previous one — days, months or years
2. Quality	**From tasty to necessary**: cooked meat with vegetables → plainer food; delicacies like **dates and sweet things** → **vegetables and cheese**	Until it becomes part of your nature
3. Quantity	Less of the simple food	Until **you eat only what the body needs**

The weights analogy: *"You don't jump to 20 kilos. You go 5, 10, 15 — you've done 10 for two or three weeks, now 11, now 12."* Same here, in reverse: **five dishes to four, and stay at four** until it is part of you; then three, and so on — **until you have forgotten you ever ate five**, as if you had always lived this way.

(Of course — taking health and everything else into account.)

וזהו שאמר אליהו עליו השלום: עשי לי משם עוגה קטנה בראשונה. (Melachim I 17:13)

Eliyahu asked the widow only for **a small cake** — *that's all I need.*

What we can take from this

"This example is extremely far from me, at least — I even feel uncomfortable talking about eating only simple foods. We all have our pleasures, our guilty pleasures, foods we know aren't good for our health." **But there is a point here we do need to work on:**

- **How attached are we to the sensual pleasures of this world?** Try to decrease that **slightly — each on our own level**.
- **Establish honestly where you are first**, and only then make a plan.
- **Take it slowly.** Go too fast and you'll have **physical, emotional and spiritual** problems.

Summary

Rabbeinu Avraham on Chayei Sarah: Yitzchak used to travel the distance from the Negev to **Be'er Lachai Roi** for **solitude and avodah** (the hitbodedut of Chapter 12). The Torah stresses he was **coming back** when he met Rivka — on his way **out**, he would not have stopped even for her. He **moved** there only **after Avraham died**, because while his father lived he would not leave him — **kibbud av** above his own spiritual preference.

The intellectual path: the battle is first a **clear decision** that this world's pleasures are **not the purpose of being human**. **Sensual pleasure** we share with animals, and the more physical it is, **the more embarrassed** we are. **Clothes** are an image for others; **mansions** are mostly for others' approval — a field of grass refreshes more; **power** pulls us from ourselves and depends on others. **Shlomo HaMelech** tried everything: **הכל הבל**.

The obstacle is habit — the chariot-rider and the peddler, the married man and the traveller, the faster whose first day is hardest. So **beginners need external training** (simple clothes, fasting, solitude) — **but it is not the goal**. For **Eliyahu, Elisha and the prophets**, perishut became **second nature**: food, clothes and home **make no difference**, like the **fourth level of bitachon**. **Proofs** that perishut is valued: **Yom Kippur** ties atonement to affliction; the **Rechavim** were rewarded; and even **false prophets** wore the hairy cloak.

Practically: habit **can't be changed in one go**. **First assess** how attached you are; then change **little by little** — **a ramp, not steps** (**ולא תעלה במעלות**): five dishes to four, then plainer food, then less — until you no longer remember wanting more. **Cold turkey fails — and even when it works, it does damage.**

Coming Up

- **Next week, Monday 6:00pm:** a skip ahead within Chapter 10 to Rabbeinu Avraham's long explanation of **Yitzchak's blessings** to Yaakov and Esav — timed for **Parashat Toldot**, taking the whole shiur. The question: if everything in this chapter is true, **why does Yitzchak bless with physical things** — and why does he **ask for food** before blessing?
- **The week after:** back to the section on **fasting**, and the apparent contradiction with the **Rambam's Eight Chapters**.
- Later: **Chapter 11**, and **Chapter 12 on hitbodedut**.

B'Ezrat Hashem

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